

Designing a Complete Internal Communication & Feedback System

Company Context:

Creative studio / tech company / game studio with 20–60 employees. The company faces unclear decisions, late or ignored feedback, micromanagement concerns, and low cross-team communication.

PART 1 – Diagnosis (Critical Thinking)

Root Causes of Communication Breakdown

1.
Unclear decision-making process
 - Cause: No formal documentation of decisions. Managers discuss in ad-hoc meetings without sharing outcomes.
 - Consequence: Teams are confused about priorities and responsibilities; developers and designers act on assumptions.
2.
Feedback delivered too late or emotionally
 - Cause: No structured feedback schedule; feedback occurs reactively.
 - Consequence: Employees feel demotivated, defensive, or ignored; trust erodes between teams.
3.
Micromanagement of developers

- Cause: Managers lack confidence in clear communication and feel the need to constantly check progress.
- Consequence: Developer morale drops; creativity is stifled.

4.

Designers feel unheard

- Cause: Decisions are communicated without input from all stakeholders; asynchronous channels are underused.
- Consequence: Designers feel undervalued, causing disengagement and slow iteration.

5.

Incorrect use of communication channels

- Cause: Casual chat tools (Slack/Discord) are used for decisions or sensitive feedback.
- Consequence: Misunderstandings arise; records of decisions and feedback are scattered or lost.

Summary: The company suffers from a lack of structured communication, unclear feedback processes, and poor alignment across roles, affecting morale, efficiency, and team cohesion.

PART 2 – Communication Architecture (System Design)

A. Communication Channels

Channel	Purpose	Who Uses	Frequency
Daily Stand-up	Share progress, blockers	All team members	Daily, 15 min
Weekly Sync	Department updates, cross-	Team leads +	Weekly, 30–45 min

	team alignment	managers	
Async Chat (Slack/Discord)	Quick questions, informal updates	All employees	Continuous, monitored daily
Decision Log (Notion)	Document final decisions, rationale	Managers + leads	Updated after every decision
Monthly All-Hands	Company-wide updates, Q&A	All employees	Monthly, 1 hour

B. Rules & Protocols

1.
Decisions must be documented in the Decision Log within 24 hours.
2.
Urgent issues can be discussed in chat; non-urgent in async threads.
3.
Feedback is never delivered publicly in meetings unless pre-agreed.
4.
Meetings require a clear agenda and expected outcome.
5.
Response to async messages should occur within 24 hours during workdays.
6.
Sensitive feedback is delivered through structured channels (1:1 or feedback forms).
7.
Daily stand-ups focus on blockers, not detailed progress reports.
8.
Approval requests must be routed through designated channels (e.g., project management tool).

PART 3 – Feedback System (Advanced)

A. Types of Feedback

- Peer-to-peer: Structured 360° feedback quarterly.

- Manager-to-team: Weekly check-ins + monthly performance feedback.
- Team-to-manager: Anonymous quarterly surveys + monthly open feedback sessions.

B. Feedback Method

- Chosen Model: SBI (Situation–Behavior–Impact)
- Reason: Clear, non-emotional, situationally grounded.
- Application:
 - Situation: “During yesterday’s design review...”
 - Behavior: “...you did not include mockups for key screens...”
 - Impact: “...this delayed the next phase of development.”

C. Feedback Safety

- 1:1 sessions for sensitive feedback to protect psychological safety.
 - Managers trained in conflict de-escalation.
 - Toxic or personal attacks redirected to HR for formal resolution.
 - Anonymous reporting available for recurring issues.
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PART 4 – Crisis Simulation

Scenario: Senior developer publicly criticizes junior designer: “Unprofessional and slow.”

Manager Immediate Actions:

1.
Calmly stop the conversation.
2.
Ask the senior developer to continue feedback privately.
3.
Check in with the junior designer to ensure support.

Reframed Feedback Example:

- “During yesterday’s sprint review (Situation), the design draft lacked X element (Behavior), which delayed our schedule (Impact). Let’s work together to prevent this next time.”

System Failure:

- Lack of public meeting protocols and structured feedback channels.

Rule Change:

- Public feedback is prohibited; all constructive criticism must use SBI in private 1:1 sessions or designated feedback channels.

PART 5 – Measurement & Improvement

KPI	What is Measured	Frequency	Action if Poor
Feedback Frequency	Number of feedback sessions per quarter	Quarterly	Schedule more structured feedback sessions

Team Satisfaction	Employee satisfaction surveys	Bi-annually	Conduct focus groups to identify pain points
Decision Clarity	% of decisions documented in Decision Log	Monthly	Audit missing entries; enforce documentation protocol
Conflict Rate	Number of reported conflicts	Monthly	Introduce mediation training or adjust feedback rules
Communication Responsiveness	Avg. response time in async tools	Weekly	Remind teams of response-time expectations

Final Notes:
This system creates clarity, protects psychological safety, and ensures structured, timely feedback while maintaining accountability. Proper measurement and continuous iteration will sustain communication efficiency and team morale.